TSA 2011

Critical Thinking

Questions taken from the TSA Oxford 2011 Section 1 question paper

Questions	Total marks	Time limit
25	25	45 minutes

Instructions

- You have **45 minutes** to answer all **25 questions**.
- Each question is worth **one mark**. There are no penalties for incorrect answers, so attempt every question.
- Each question has five options, A to E. Choose the one option you consider correct.
- Calculators are **not** permitted. You may use this paper for rough working.
- Questions are numbered 1 to 25 for this set. The number in brackets shows the question's number in the original TSA 2011 paper, e.g. **1 (Q3)**.

How the time limit was set

The time limit follows the TARA Critical Thinking module (22 questions in 40 minutes), scaled to the 25 questions in this set: 25 × 40 ÷ 22 = 45.45 minutes, rounded to the nearest minute (45 minutes).

Score: _____ / 25

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1 (Q1) 11% of nurses across the country would like to leave the profession. However, this figure rises to 39% amongst nurses who are working alternating shift systems, which mix day, evening and night shifts. It was found that many nurses preferred one type of shift most of the time, whether that involved working early, late or through the night. Employers should urgently review staffing arrangements to avoid the compulsory, alternating patterns. This would make nurses' working hours more compatible with their social and family lives. A further benefit would be a reduction in the cost of training new nurses to replace those leaving.

What is the best expression of the main conclusion of this argument?

A The health service should adapt shift patterns to suit nurses in order to retain staff.

B Alternating shift systems cause nurses to want leave the health service.

C Many nurses prefer a regular pattern of work.

D Some nurses would like to leave the profession no matter what their shift pattern.

E 61% of nurses prefer alternating shift patterns.

2 (Q3) Some recent films have been very expensive to make, but have not been the big box-office hits that would have justified the expense. At the same time, there have been films made very cheaply which have been received with both huge critical and popular acclaim. Indeed, some directors who have made successful low-budget films have gone on to make unsuccessful but expensive films. It is obvious then that if directors want to make popular films, they should stick to low budgets.

Which one of the following is the best statement of the flaw in the argument above?

A Critics are often wrong in their predictions about the popularity of films.

B The cost of making a film is normally greater than its original budget.

C The cost of a film need not be the factor that determines its popularity.

D The popularity of a film would justify a high level of expense in making it.

E The public does not necessarily know whether a film has been expensive or cheap to make.

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3 (Q4) It is clear that the world is getting warmer. The only thing that could slow down this process of global warming, and avert ecological disaster, would be an immediate switch to green technologies. If global warming continues at the present rate, some species will be unable to live in the warmer conditions. They will need to move to cooler places than they now occupy, for example closer to the poles, or higher up mountains. Not all of these species will be able to reach cooler climates, because of the long distances they would have to travel. Some of those that could move would end up in overcrowded habitats, which would make successful breeding impossible.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A Most species require cool habitats for successful breeding.

B Many species will be able to adapt to living in warmer climates.

C Endangered species will survive if we switch to green technologies.

D It is not possible to avert the ecological disaster caused by global warming.

E Unless we switch immediately to green technologies, some species will not survive.

4 (Q5) Cannabis smoking is widespread, even though it is illegal. It is also more dangerous to health than most people realise. If we want to reduce the use of cannabis, it should be legalised. People do not turn away from dangerous habits unless they are fully aware of the damage these habits can cause. We should have learnt this lesson from the example of tobacco smoking, which has declined dramatically because people have seen that it results in deaths from lung cancer.

Which one of the following is an assumption underlying the above argument?

A People who still smoke tobacco are unaware that it can affect their health.

B Unless cannabis smoking is legalised, its dangers will not be widely known.

C If tobacco smoking had been illegal, it would have been less widespread.

D There has been insufficient research on the damage caused by cannabis smoking.

E Cannabis users are motivated by the fact that they are engaging in an illegal activity.

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5 (Q9) If children are sitting in rows in a classroom, the teacher can have eye contact with all of them while she is explaining something to them. This is not always possible if they are sitting in groups around tables. Also, when they look up, instead of seeing the child opposite in a group and being tempted to talk, they see the teacher. So, sitting in rows helps children to concentrate better on their work and should therefore be the standard arrangement in every school classroom.

Which one of the following, if true, would most strengthen the above argument?

A Rows of desks take up no more classroom space than tables.

B Some children are easily distracted whether they sit in rows or in groups.

C Sitting in groups of between four and seven makes discussion work easier.

D Traditionalists argue that teaching the whole class in rows is best.

E If desks are arranged in rows, children can all see visual aids more easily.

6 (Q10) "There are more police officers than ever before in the history of this country. We have more police officers and more community support officers. That is why, last week, crime was down. Crime is down 30 per cent."

Which of the following states the flaw in the argument above?

A Community support officers don't have the same powers as police officers.

B Crime levels can be measured in different ways.

C Crime could have fallen if there had been no increase in policing.

D The fact that crime was down last week does not mean it will stay down.

E Having more police officers may mean more crime is being detected.

7 (Q11) The differences between human beings are sometimes more striking than the similarities. There is a minority of people who, driven by a competitive urge to be the first or the best, undertake ambitious expeditions involving severe physical deprivations, high risk of fatality, and extreme isolation. Compare these people to the majority who prefer an easy, risk free life of comfort and we can see that one human being can be as different from another in their behaviour as two different species of animal. Any attempt to form general rules about human behaviour needs to bear this variation in mind.

Which one of the following best expresses the conclusion of the passage above?

A Members of the human race can be as different in their behaviour as two separate species of animal.

B Humans who take risks in the interests of achieving unusual feats are untypical.

C Variation in human behaviour makes it difficult to generalise.

D Differences between people can be more striking than similarities.

E Human beings are superior to all other animals.

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8 (Q15) Similar effects have similar causes. The problem is deciding when one set of effects sufficiently resembles another to infer a similar cause. You say that the universe resembles a man-made object like a house, so its cause must also be similar, an intelligent designer, resembling human beings. But is the universe so like a house? It seems to resemble an animal or vegetable just as closely, so why should its origin not lie in reproduction or some vegetative process? The universe contains many classes of effects and objects, all with their different causes. There seems to be no compelling reason for concluding that the universe as a whole resembles one of these classes of effects or objects more closely than another.

Which one of the following is a conclusion that can reliably be drawn from the above reasoning?

A The universe bears no resemblance to a man-made object like a house.

B The inference that the universe and man-made objects have similar causes is not justified.

C The world resembles a vegetable more closely than a house.

D The universe is not the result of intelligent design.

E The most likely origin of the universe is a reproductive process.

9 (Q16) At first glance, there is no phenomenon creepier than crop circles - huge geometric designs that appear in fields overnight seemingly without cause, explanation or reason. UFO enthusiasts are quick to supply all three, by attributing the patterns to alien visitors seeking to communicate with humans, using laser beams or other advanced technology to flatten the crops. These fanciful claims can fortunately be dismissed thanks to two quite mundane observations. Firstly, ordinary Earth-born individuals have repeatedly demonstrated how to produce the effects with nothing more elaborate than a rope and a plank. Secondly, there is a clear parallel for the phenomenon in the form of urban graffiti. Sneaking into fields to make crop circles is simply a rural variation of a widespread and well-documented human urge.

Which one of the following is an implicit, underlying assumption that is made by the above argument?

A Where two explanations compete we should accept the more ordinary one.

B There is nothing difficult or technical about producing crop circles.

C Alien visitors would not try to communicate with humans by flattening crops.

D No visits from intelligent aliens have as yet been documented.

E The appearance overnight of huge geometrical designs is creepy if it can not be explained.

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10 (Q17) When you install a burglar alarm in your home, you do so presumably because the cost of the alarm is less than the expected benefits. The cost of a burglary, if one occurs, is likely to be much higher than the cost of fitting an alarm. A clearly visible box on an outside wall of an alarmed house alerts and discourages potential thieves. Because your house is less likely to be burgled, your neighbour's house may be more vulnerable. Therefore, while there may be little impact on overall crime levels, expensive security devices reduce crimes against those with the devices but increase crimes against those without.

Which one of the following, if true, would most weaken the above argument?

A For similar houses, a higher percentage of those without intruder alarms are burgled than those with alarms.

B As the percentage of houses with intruder alarms increased from 40% to 90%, house burglary rates fell by 60% and there was a rise in street muggings of 100%.

C Burglars perceive an alarm as a signal that there are items well worth stealing in a house, while no alarm indicates less valuable contents.

D Only 60% of houses with alarms set the alarm every day.

E Burglars know that 25% of all visible alarm boxes are fakes, but cannot tell the fake from the genuine.

11 (Q21) It would be a good idea if the police force was separated into two divisions, one for proper policing i.e. protecting citizens and upholding law and order, and the other for road traffic. This second division could be combined with traffic wardens as basically they are doing a similar job: obtaining money from road users. Perhaps then there would be a proper focus put on catching criminals and protecting the law-abiding public, and we would have a police force doing the job they were actually intended to do.

Which one of the following best describes the flaw in the above argument?

A It overlooks the fact that many traffic offences are both criminal and a serious danger to the public.

B It rests on the false assumption that the police do not protect citizens or catch criminals.

C It ignores the fact that traffic wardens and the police have different duties and different powers.

D It wrongly equates protecting citizens with catching criminals.

E It implies that the police once did the job they were supposed to do.

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12 (Q22) If you practise playing a musical instrument, your playing will get better. I have not practised playing the piano, so my playing has not got better. I have an exam in two month's time. So I must practise every day if I want to do well.

Which of the following most closely parallels the reasoning in the argument?

A If you practise playing the cello your playing will get better. Dawn has not practised much but her playing has got better so she must have done enough. She may even pass her Grade III exam next month.

B If you work hard at a sport, you will become better. I have not worked hard at my trampolining, so I have not become better. There is a competition next month. So I must work hard if I want to do well.

C If you work hard at running you will get faster. I have worked hard to get faster, and I have started winning races. There is a race next week. If I want to win it I must keep practising.

D People who practise a craft get better at that craft. All master craftsmen and women have put long hours of practice into their art. It is impossible to become an expert without practising.

E Practise makes perfect. I have practised hard on my violin so I should soon be perfect. I have a competition coming up soon which I fully expect to win.

13 (Q23) Legislation is needed in order to prevent the abuse of genetic testing by insurance companies. New genetic tests may reveal how likely an individual is to suffer from certain debilitating or fatal conditions in later life. Without legislation, insurance companies might make such tests compulsory and make those at risk pay more for insurance. This would be unfair. We do not choose our genes; we are born with them. People should not be penalised for things over which they have no control.

Which one of the following best illustrates the principle underlying the above argument?

A Kylie did not deliberately get her accounts wrong, but she should pay the fine anyway. She should have made sure the accounts were right.

B Some people have lost everything in the flood. Their insurance companies are responsible for their losses. Therefore the Government should not help out.

C Philip should not receive any help paying his debts, however sorry one may be for him. He knew in advance that his business venture was very risky.

D Late payment normally incurs a fine. But Jamuna's payment was held up because postal workers were on strike, so she should not be made to pay the fine.

E Three people were not properly informed of possible financial losses when they joined the scheme. Their financial advisors should lose their professional licences.

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14 (Q27) Britain's property market is in the midst of a full-scale slump with house prices falling at their fastest rate in 15 years, according to a new study. But why is there an assumption that continuing rises in house prices is a good thing? Why not see the fall in house prices as a welcome change? House prices as a percentage of income are grossly overpriced. Low interest rates and cheap mortgages have led to the property market, particularly in London, being overvalued. Surely this will make houses more affordable. First time buyers will be happy beneficiaries of a housing slump. Others finding a silver lining in the gloom are those in rural communities for whom a house had seemed simply out of reach.

Which one of the following is the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Low interest rates and cheap mortgages have led to an overvaluing of the property market.

B It is always assumed that continually rising house prices are a good thing.

C Rural communities will no longer find buying a house out of reach.

D Surely a slump in prices will make buying a house more affordable.

E We should view the fall in house prices as a good thing.

15 (Q28) The average life expectancy in working class areas of London was significantly higher than in similar areas in other major cities in the first half of the nineteenth century. In London during this time drinking tea had become a part of daily life amongst the poor. The reason for this was a combination of availability and cost. Boats bringing tea to the country docked in London and a certain amount was sold off directly to local markets. At this time in the rest of the country tea was still regarded as a luxury, consumed only by the better off.

Which one of the following conclusions is best supported by the passage above?

A The drinking of tea increases life expectancy.

B Everyone ought to include tea in their daily diet.

C There may be properties of tea which are beneficial to health.

D The growing popularity of tea led to a decrease in the consumption of more harmful drinks, such as gin.

E For the poor tea was a substitute for food.

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16 (Q29) A recent study by a drugs company found that the amount of money spent on a specific pill used for the treatment of Alzheimer's disease in the UK showed wide regional variation. Alzheimer's is a condition associated with the ageing process. In some areas the expenditure was as low as £1 per head of the population over 65 whereas in others it was as high as £10 per head. These pills are the most effective treatment for this condition that is currently available. Therefore, this is another example of 'post-code lottery' where the effectiveness of treatment for a health condition will depend upon where you live.

Which one of the following is an assumption underlying the above argument?

A The pills are very successful in halting the progress of Alzheimer's disease.

B The drugs company that did the research doesn't have a vested interest in selling the pills.

C There are no regional variations in the incidence of Alzheimer's in the 65+ age group.

D There are no regional variations in the number of people in the 65+ age group.

E It is not possible to develop Alzheimer's disease below the age of 65.

17 (Q33) In a high speed police chase, police drivers sometimes lose sight of the car they are chasing. But that’s no reason to give up. All they have to do is take the first left, and then the first left again. Pursued drivers are likely to keep taking turns as they come up, as this seems instinctively like the best way to lose someone who is following them. They are not going to turn right as this involves waiting and checking for oncoming traffic. Therefore take a couple of left turns and the police car will soon have their criminal in sight once again!

Which of the following, if true, would strengthen this argument?

A Car chases tend to end with the pursued driver losing control of their vehicle.

B Drivers in TV car chases tend to turn left rather than right when pursued.

C Police drivers are usually able to sustain faster average speeds over a length of time than other drivers.

D Police drivers usually request overhead assistance from a helicopter when chasing criminals in cars.

E Two left turns might take the criminal where they want to be going.

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18 (Q34) The museum has decided to spend money in the hope of staying profitable and, therefore, remaining open. It has opened an expensive new front hall, which is very big and well planned, and will undoubtedly impress new visitors. For serious students, however, it has nothing to offer that was not there before. All the scholars who want to do so already use the museum, they will continue to come however artistic the displays may or may not be. So, it was a waste to spend so much money on appearances, the money should have been spent on improving conditions for those who come to study.

Which one of the following is the best statement of the flaw in the above argument?

A The museum cannot be sure that new visitors will be attracted by its new front hall.

B There is no evidence that visitors to museums are interested in the conditions in which the contents are displayed.

C If scholars will continue to come anyway, the museum will not make more money by improving their conditions.

D There is no contact or sympathy between serious scholars and members of the general public in museums.

E It is regular users, and not potential new visitors, to the museum who deserve to be rewarded.

19 (Q35) England is set to become the most crowded country in Europe as its population grows by a third over the next 50 years, according to official projections. There are currently some 50 million people in England, but in 50 years this could hit 68 million - 1,349 for every square mile. Opposition political parties, who have obtained the data from the Office for National Statistics, demanded restrictions on migration levels. The opposition spokeswoman for immigration said "This demonstrates the real pressure public services are being put under as a result of the failed immigration policy of the present government, which the electorate are increasingly recognising." Continued unrestricted population growth will lead to extremist political parties benefiting at the ballot box.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Extremist parties will gain political capital from the growth in population.

B England is set to become the most crowded country in Europe over the next 50 years.

C Public services will come under increasing pressure as a result of immigration policy.

D The electorate are dissatisfied with the government's immigration policy.

E Opposition parties believe immigration is the sole reason for the projected rise in population in England.

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20 (Q39) Many people who live near to mobile phone masts are worried that radiation from these masts will damage their health. Mobile phones themselves have also been suspected of emitting dangerous levels of radiation, and a report recommended that children should be discouraged from making non-essential calls. Emission of radiation from the masts is much lower than that from a mobile phone. A few seconds making a phone call is comparable to 24 hours of exposure from a mast. Radiation from both these sources is below the international guidelines as to what is a dangerous level, but no one can yet be certain if these guidelines accurately reflect the level of risk.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A People who use mobile phones are putting their health at risk.

B The international guidelines underestimate the risk to health from low levels of radiation.

C The health risk from living near a phone mast is lower than that from using a mobile phone.

D People who live near mobile phone masts overestimate the risks to their health from these masts.

E If extensive use of mobile phones is not harmful to health, radiation from a mast is unlikely to be a risk.

21 (Q40) University education is not a matter of forcing through the largest number of graduates at the lowest possible short-term cost. This would not serve the needs of the current generation of students and, even from a narrow economic viewpoint, it would not promote economic prosperity in the long term. It is often a poor economic practice to skimp on the production costs of a product, even when you are only interested in the eventual monetary profit to be made from it. But in any event university education has wider purposes than merely the promotion of economic prosperity.

Which of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A The principal purpose of university education is to serve the needs of the present generation of students.

B The principal purpose of university education is to promote the long term economic prosperity of the community.

C The more money the manufacturer spends on the production of a product, the greater the eventual profit is likely to be.

D Policies of cost-cutting are likely to reduce the extent to which the university education will achieve its overall purpose.

E Universities should be managed so as to make a monetary profit, but they should also promote certain non-financial values.

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22 (Q41) The preservation of First Class sections on trains is indefensible. This is not because it is socially divisive, which it is; nor because it is very expensive, which it also is; but because it inevitably leads to a relatively poorer service in Standard Class sections of trains. Clearly, in order to attract First Class passengers it is necessary to maintain certain levels of discomfort in those compartments which cater to the great majority of travellers. There is, for example, a powerful disincentive to make more space generally available on trains, as one of the main inducements to travel First Class is to escape overcrowding and be assured of a seat. Yet, additional space would add significantly to the safety and comfort of most passengers.

Which one of the following, if true, would most weaken the above argument?

A More people are now using First Class sections on trains than ever before.

B The whole rail service benefits from the increased revenue generated by the high cost of First Class tickets.

C On many trains the First Class section occupies only a small proportion of the total accommodation.

D No one is excluded from travelling in the First Class sections of trains, provided they are prepared to pay the higher fare.

E Some people who travel in First Class sections of trains would not use the trains if there were no First Class sections.

23 (Q45) Although study leave in the run up to exams is traditional, and benefits well-motivated, organised students, recent thinking suggests that it is not the best way to improve results. Some students are required to do housework or help in the family business rather than studying. Many others spend time playing computer games, watching daytime TV or hanging around with friends instead of revising. Schools which provide in-school study areas with teacher supervision and a programme of booster revision sessions are getting more A*s and fewer Ds. It is time to ditch study leave.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the argument?

A Many students do not make good use of their study leave.

B Students who work hard find study leave useful.

C Study leave is not the best way for students to gain high results.

D Study leave ought to be abandoned.

E Traditional methods of education need to be updated to improve results.

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24 (Q46) Land reform is urgently needed in the UK. It is well documented that around two-thirds of Britain is owned by just 0.3% of the population. Many of the largest estates have been in the hands of the same families for centuries, and were acquired under outdated feudal laws, often by means of aggression. If these families had any sense of social justice in the 21st century they would by now have voluntarily surrendered all but the acreage they needed for personal privacy. _____ the state should confiscate all excessive land holdings without compensation and redistribute them into the families of workers and taxpayers at affordable prices.

Which of the following phrases, inserted in the blank space, most logically completes the above argument?

A In the current economic climate, ...

B On the other hand, ...

C This being the case, ...

D Therefore, on legal grounds, ...

E Since they have not, ...

25 (Q47) All trees have leaves. An oak is a tree. Therefore oaks have leaves.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the argument?

A All leaves grow on trees. That plant has leaves. Therefore that plant is a tree.

B All oaks have leaves. That tree has leaves. Therefore that tree is an oak.

C All plants have leaves. That leaf is an oak leaf. Therefore all plants are oaks.

D All trees have leaves. That plant has leaves. Therefore that plant is a tree.

E All trees have leaves. That plant is not a tree. Therefore that plant does not have leaves.

END OF TEST

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